Saviours AI

ICSE CLASS 10 · 2027 SYLLABUS

SIDE KICK

English Literature

Every Class X story and poem in Treasure Chest, with themes, quotes, devices and HOT questions.



EVERY TOPPER HAS A SIDEKICK

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Hey. I'm your Sidekick.

I live inside this book. Wherever things get tricky, I pop up with a tip, a trap to dodge, or a question the board loves to ask. Read the chapter, then try my HOT questions. Deal?



Aligned to the official ICSE 2027 syllabus. If it's in the syllabus, it's in here.

SIDEKICK TIP
Shortcuts, mnemonics and exam hacks.

FUN FACT
Things that make the concept stick.

REAL LIFE
Where this shows up outside the exam hall.

KEY POINT
Definitions and laws you must write exactly.

HOT QUESTION
Higher-order thinking. Try before you peek.

✦ NEW
Added in this edition to match the 2027 syllabus.

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01

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

With the Photographer

A man just wants an honest portrait. The photographer wants to rebuild his face. Leacock turns a studio visit into a comic battle between plain truth and polished pretence.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Stephen Leacock
- Humorous satire
- First-person narrator
- Appearance vs reality
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Stephen Leacock (1869 to 1944) was an English-born Canadian writer and economics professor at McGill University, famous for gentle humour that pokes fun at human pride and fuss. The story is told by an ordinary man, an "I" who sounds a lot like Leacock himself, and it is written in a light, chatty voice.

The piece belongs to an age when portraits were taken in a studio with a huge wooden camera, a black cloth and a plate that had to be developed and then **retouched by hand**. That retouching is the target of the joke.



FUN FACT

Because the narrator talks straight to us, the humour comes from the gap between his calm, polite words and the nonsense going on around him.

Story in Six Steps

1. 1. The long wait

The narrator goes to a studio for a simple likeness that his friends can keep after he is gone. He is made to sit in a waiting room for a very long time with old magazines, which already tells us that the studio takes itself far too seriously.

2. 2. The ritual of the studio

He is led to the sitting room where the photographer fusses with a long pole, blinds and curtains. He mutters about 'effects' and then vanishes under a black cloth at the back of the camera, so that he seems to be worshipping the machine rather than meeting a customer.

3. 3. The insult

Instead of taking a picture, the photographer studies the narrator's face and says it is all wrong: the ears, the eyes and even the fullness of his cheeks. He wants to press it into a 'better' shape with his own hands.

4. 4. The contortions

He twists the narrator's head, asks for a raised forehead, a relaxed mouth, a calm and vacant look, and then bends his neck at odd angles. The narrator, polite and tired, obeys like a puppet.

5. 5. The proof

The prints arrive, and the face in them is a stranger's. The photographer proudly says he has worked on the plate with his drawing skills, so the picture is more his creation than a record of the sitter.

6. 6. The refusal

The narrator will not accept an improved face that is not his. He tells the artist to keep his masterpiece, and leaves the studio, disappointed but with his dignity and his own face intact.

Characters

CHARACTER	TRAITS
The narrator	Mild, patient, polite, and humble about his looks. He asks only for a plain likeness. His quiet courage appears at the end when he says no.
The photographer	Self-important, bossy and rude. He treats a human being as raw material and believes art must 'improve' nature. He never listens to the customer.

Themes and Messages

- **Appearance vs reality.** The finished portrait shows a glossy invention, not the real man.
- **Pride of the professional.** The photographer's skill has turned into arrogance; he trusts his rules over the person in front of him.
- **Self-acceptance.** The narrator's refusal says: my face may not be perfect, but it is mine.
- **Satire on vanity and artificial beauty.** The story laughs at the habit of tidying up the truth, which is why it still feels modern in the age of photo filters.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Humour and satire	Gentle exaggeration of the photographer's demands makes his pride look silly without anyone shouting.
Irony	The man called an 'artist' destroys the very likeness he is paid to capture. The narrator seems to see prayer in the camera cloth, while the man is only hunting for effects.
Hyperbole	Orders such as dropping the ears or rolling the eyes in a certain way are deliberately impossible.
First-person voice	We feel the narrator's embarrassment directly, and his polite understatement is funnier than complaining.
Tone	Light, amused and mock-polite, turning sharper only at the last refusal.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
"remembered by", a simple photograph	His modest aim: an honest memory for friends, nothing grand.
"your face is quite wrong"	The photographer's tactless verdict; he condemns the face before he has taken a single shot.
"more chubby"	He wants to remake the sitter to fit an ideal, an absurd demand.
"face as God made it"	The narrator's calm pride in being himself; the emotional high point.
"drawing skill" used on the plate	The photographer admits that the picture is partly his invention, not a record.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
retouch	to alter a photograph or negative by hand to remove or change details
proof	a first print shown to the customer for approval
vanity	excessive pride in one's looks or ability
placid	calm and untroubled
contort	twist into a strange shape
likeness	a picture that looks like the real person
pretentious	trying to seem more important or artistic than one is
draughtsman	a person skilled at drawing

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

The narrator is told by the photographer that his face is 'quite wrong' and that it should be made a little fuller before the picture is taken.

Q. Where is the narrator at this moment and why has he come?
Ans. He is in the photographer's studio, in the sitting room, and he has come to have a simple portrait made for the people who will want to remember him.

Q. What is wrong with the photographer's remark?
Ans. It is a rude and unprofessional comment. A photographer should record a face, not criticise it, so the remark exposes his arrogance.

Q. What does the narrator's reaction show about him?
Ans. He stays polite and does not argue at once, which shows he is gentle and patient. His quiet endurance also makes the situation funnier.

Context

The photographer disappears under a black cloth at the rear of the camera and the narrator thinks he looks as if he is praying.

Q. Who is speaking, and what does the narrator mean by 'praying'?
Ans. The narrator is speaking. He means the photographer's stillness and bowed head look like worship, as though the camera were an altar.

Q. What is ironic about this?
Ans. The man is not praying at all. He is hunting for lighting and effects, so a moment that looks holy is really about vanity and technique.

Context

The photographer shows the finished proof, which looks nothing like the sitter, and says that he has used his skill with the pencil on it.

Q. What does the narrator think of the proof?
Ans. He finds it unrecognisable. It is a smooth, fantasy face and not his own.

Q. What does the photographer's explanation reveal?
Ans. It reveals that he sees himself as a creator who improves nature, not a craftsman who records it.

Q. What does the narrator do?
Ans. He rejects the picture, tells the photographer to keep it, and leaves without being persuaded.

Short Answer Questions

Q. Why does the narrator go to the photographer?
Ans. He wants an honest, simple portrait that his friends can keep and recall him by.

Q. How does the photographer prepare for the shot?
Ans. He plays with curtains and a pole to adjust the light, then hides under the camera cloth, and then twists the narrator's head and neck into odd positions.

Q. What does the narrator mean by saying his face is as God made it?
Ans. He means he accepts his features as they naturally are and does not want them altered to suit someone's idea of beauty.

Q. Why is the story humorous?
Ans. Because the photographer's ridiculous demands are described in a calm, polite voice, and the more serious he is, the sillier he looks.

Q. What is satirised in the story?
Ans. The story satirises vanity, artificial beauty, and professionals who put their own cleverness above their customers.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Show how the photographer's behaviour makes the studio visit comic. (about 150 words)
Ans. The comedy lies in the gap between what a customer expects and what the photographer does. The narrator expects a quick, honest portrait. First he is kept waiting for a long time. Then the photographer fusses over curtains, vanishes under a black cloth, and declares the sitter's face wrong. He twists the head, asks for a vacant look, and wants a fuller face. All this is told by the narrator in a mild voice, so every outrageous demand seems even more absurd. The final proof, a stranger's face drawn over the sitter's, completes the joke: the artist has replaced the subject with his own idea. The narrator's dry refusal ends the story with a laugh that also carries a point about pride.

Q. Describe the character of the narrator and say what the story teaches. (about 150 words)
Ans. The narrator is humble, patient and good-natured. He does not fuss about his looks, and he quietly cooperates even when he is pushed into strange poses. Yet he has a core of self-respect that appears when he sees the proof. He does not allow another man to rewrite his face. The story teaches that real worth lies in being oneself, and that we should resist pressure to look or act according to artificial standards. It also warns experts not to confuse their skill with the right to decide what a person ought to look like.

HOT Questions

- A friend says: 'The photographer was only doing his job; the narrator was over-sensitive.' Do you agree? Argue with evidence.
- How is the photographer's attitude similar to today's photo filters and editing apps? Is it harmless or harmful?
- Why do you think Leacock lets the narrator tell the story himself, rather than describing the photographer from outside?
- Suppose the narrator had accepted the improved photograph. How would the story's message change?

Quick Recap

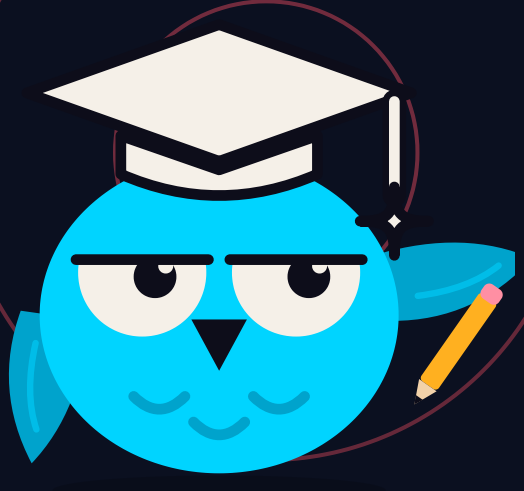
- Writer: Stephen Leacock, humorist. Story told in the first person.
- Plot: long wait, fussing, insulting remarks, forced poses, a stranger's face in the proof, and a firm refusal.
- Themes: appearance vs reality, professional vanity, self-acceptance.
- Devices: satire, irony, hyperbole, understatement. Tone: light and amused.

02

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

The Elevator

A young boy, a father who will not listen, a very old lift and one frightening passenger. Sleator builds fear step by step and leaves you hanging.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- William Sleator
- Psychological horror
- Parent and child
- Open ending
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

William Sleator (1945 to 2011) was an American author known for science-fiction and horror stories for young readers. He is good at making ordinary places such as a lift, a house or a school feel threatening, and at writing about teenagers who feel alone and misunderstood.

The story is told in the third person, but we see everything through **Martin**, a twelve-year-old who is already timid. He and his father have moved into an old apartment building, and Martin's flat is high up, on the seventeenth floor.



KEY POINT

This is a story where the mood matters more than the action. Sleator never explains the lady, and that silence is his most effective tool.

Story in Seven Steps

1. 1. A bad building

Martin moves with his father into a gloomy old block. The lift is the worst thing about it: it groans, sticks and jerks. The boy is afraid of being shut in, and the building has made it worse.

2. 2. A father without sympathy

When Martin says he dislikes the lift, his father laughs at him and tells him to behave like a man. Martin's fear is not taken seriously; he is only made to feel weak.

3. 3. The first meeting

A large, silent woman with pale, tiny eyes steps in on a lower floor. She stares at Martin the whole ride, and he feels squeezed into a corner.

4. 4. She knows where he lives

She presses the button for the eighteenth floor, just above his own. Martin realises that she has found out exactly where he lives. His anxiety turns into real panic.

5. 5. Trying the stairs

Martin decides to avoid the lift and walks. The stairwell is just as dim and echoing. He tells his father about the woman, but the father brushes it away as imagination.

6. 6. The accident

Martin falls on the stairs and breaks his leg. With crutches the lift is now his only way up and down, and it is the very place he wants to avoid.

7. 7. "Hello, Martin"

In the lift again, the woman enters. This time she smiles, greets him by name, laughs and presses the stop button. The story stops there; we do not learn what happens.

Characters

CHARACTER	TRAITS
Martin	Twelve years old, thin, shy and imaginative. His fears are real to him, and he is lonely because nobody believes him.
Martin's father	Strict and impatient. He confuses toughness with courage, scolds instead of comforting, and so leaves his son defenceless.
The woman in the lift	Large, silent, staring. We never learn her name, purpose or even whether she is real. She stands for the fear we cannot explain.

Themes and Messages

- **Fear and the unknown.** What we cannot explain frightens us more than a clearly visible danger.
- **Parent-child gap.** The father's dismissal turns a worry into a nightmare. A listening adult might have changed everything.
- **Loneliness and helplessness.** Martin's broken leg and the closed lift make his isolation physical as well as emotional.
- **The power of suggestion.** By not describing the ending, Sleator makes each reader invent a worse one.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Suspense	Each meeting with the woman is slightly more threatening than the last: stare, button, name, stop.
Setting	The closed lift mirrors the boy's feeling of being trapped.
Foreshadowing	The ugly noises of the lift and the father's mocking prepare us for the trouble to come.
Irony	Martin avoids the lift and ends up breaking his leg, which forces him back into it.
Open ending (cliffhanger)	The story ends the moment the lift stops, so the horror stays with the reader.
Tone	Tense, uneasy and increasingly frightening.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
“Now she knows I live on seventeen”	The moment the boy’s mild fear becomes specific terror.
father’s ‘man’ talk	Shows his refusal to take fear seriously; he insults instead of helping.
“Hello, Martin”	A greeting that is chilling because she should not know his name.
the stop button	The woman takes control; Martin’s escape is now cut off.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
dilapidated	old and falling to pieces
claustrophobia	fear of enclosed spaces
timid	shy and easily frightened
ominous	suggesting something bad will happen
stairwell	the vertical space containing the staircase
cliffhanger	an ending that leaves the outcome undecided
dismiss	to treat as unworthy of attention
crutches	supports used to walk when a leg is injured

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

Martin’s father told him he was being foolish and said he must stop acting like a coward about a mere lift.

Q. Why is Martin afraid of the lift?
Ans. The lift is old, noisy and slow, and Martin fears being trapped inside it, so the machine becomes a symbol of everything he cannot control.

Q. What does the father’s attitude show?
Ans. It shows a harsh and unsympathetic parent who thinks courage can be forced by mockery. He ignores his son’s real feelings.

Q. How does this attitude affect the story?
Ans. Martin has no one to turn to, so the fear grows unchecked and he faces the woman alone.

Context

The woman looks at Martin and presses the button of the floor just above his own.

Q. Who is the woman, and why does her action alarm Martin?
Ans. She is a stranger, unnamed in the story. By choosing the floor beside his, she shows that she knows where he lives, so his home no longer seems safe.

Q. What effect does this have on Martin?
Ans. His ordinary unease becomes panic, and he begins to avoid the lift and plan escapes.

Context

The lift reaches a floor, the woman steps in, smiles, calls the boy by his name, laughs and presses the stop button.

Q. What changes in the woman's behaviour this time?
Ans. Earlier she only stared in silence. Now she speaks, smiles and acts to stop the lift, as though she had planned it all along.

Q. Why is the ending effective?
Ans. It stops at the most frightening moment and gives no explanation, so readers fill the gap with their own worst fears.

Short Answer Questions

Q. What is the lift like, and how does Martin feel about it?
Ans. It is old, noisy and unreliable, jerking and groaning as it moves. Martin is afraid of being trapped in it, so he dreads every ride.

Q. How did Martin try to avoid the lift?
Ans. He used the stairs, though they were poorly lit and tiring, and he even tried to keep out of the woman's way.

Q. What happened on the stairs?
Ans. Martin fell and broke his leg, so he had to depend on the lift.

Q. Why was the woman's greeting so frightening?
Ans. He had never told her his name. Her knowing it suggested she had been watching him.

Q. What type of story is The Elevator?
Ans. A psychological horror story that creates fear through mood and suspense, not through violent events.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Discuss how Sleator builds suspense in the story. (about 150 words)
Ans. Sleator builds suspense gradually. He begins with Martin's general fear of the old lift, then adds the silent woman who stares at him. The next stage is the discovery that she chooses a floor close to his, so the danger becomes personal. Martin's attempt to use the stairs and his accident remove his last means of escape. The

final meeting is the climax: she speaks, smiles and stops the lift. The lack of explanation at the end keeps the tension alive long after we stop reading. The single setting, the small cast, and plain language all keep the mood tight.

Q. What does the story say about the relationship between a parent and a child? (about 150 words)
Ans. The story shows how damaging it can be when a parent will not listen. Martin's father is not cruel in a violent way, but he is impatient and uses ridicule in place of comfort. He treats fear as weakness and tells his son to harden up. Because Martin is dismissed, he must fight his fears alone, and they grow. The father's attitude therefore adds to the horror of the story. Sleator suggests that children need adults who will believe them, reassure them and help them deal with what frightens them.

HOT Questions

- Is the woman real or only a product of Martin's fear? Support your view using details from the story.
- If the father had listened to Martin on the first day, how might the story have changed?
- Why do you think Sleator left the ending open? Would a full explanation have made the story better?
- Does the lift stand for something beyond a machine? Suggest what it might symbolise.

Quick Recap

- Writer: William Sleator, American. Genre: psychological horror.
- Plot: bad lift, mocking father, silent woman, she knows his floor, stairs and a broken leg, 'Hello, Martin' and the stop button.
- Themes: fear of the unknown, parental neglect, helplessness.
- Devices: suspense, foreshadowing, irony, open ending.

03

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

The Girl Who Can

Adjoa is seven, shy, and ashamed of her thin legs. Her grandmother says they will never do. One race changes how a whole family thinks.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Ama Ata Aidoo
- Ghana
- Body image
- Tradition vs talent
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Ama Ata Aidoo (1942 to 2023) was a Ghanaian writer, playwright and educator. Her stories often look at the lives of African women and at the clash between old customs and new opportunities. She also served in government as Ghana's Minister of Education.

The story is set in a village in Ghana called **Hasodzi**. A seven-year-old, Adjoa, lives with her mother (called **Maami**) and grandmother (**Nana**). The narrator begins in a chatty, storyteller's voice, as though talking to a listener at home.



FUN FACT

The title is a clue to the message. The whole story is about a girl others think 'cannot', who turns out to be the girl who can.

Story in Six Steps

1. 1. A grandmother's worry

Nana keeps saying that Adjoa's legs are too thin. In her view a woman needs strong, shapely legs to carry loads, farm, and later bear children, so she predicts trouble.

2. 2. A child who hides

Adjoa overhears the remarks and feels ashamed. She stops speaking up, since adults either laugh or tell children to be quiet, and she quietly studies other women's legs to see what 'good' ones look like.

3. 3. A secret skill

Adjoa loves school, which is a long walk away. Nobody at home knows that she is a very fast runner and always beats the others in races.

4. 4. A surprise selection

Her school chooses her to represent it at the district sports week. Maami and Nana are astonished, and Nana, though unsure, helps to prepare her clothes.

5. 5. The big day

Adjoa runs in the competition, and the unlikely thin legs carry her past every rival to win the cup for the best junior athlete.

6. 6. A changed family

Nana, moved and proud, understands the truth and quietly accepts that those legs are strong. Adjoa, who once felt small, finally feels recognised.

Characters

CHARACTER	TRAITS
Adjoa	Quiet, observant and sensitive, but determined. She hides her pain and her talent, and quietly proves herself by action, not argument.
Nana (grandmother)	Traditional and outspoken. Her views come from the village's expectations, not malice. She is capable of change when she sees the evidence.
Maami (mother)	Gentler than Nana, but also puzzled by her daughter. She shares in the shock and the later pride.
The narrator	A warm, plain-speaking storyteller who sides with the child, and lets us see events through her eyes.

Themes and Messages

- **Tradition vs individuality.** The village judges a girl by her body and her future duties; Adjoa's talent breaks that mould.
- **Self-worth and body image.** Even a seven-year-old can feel crushed by what elders say about her looks.
- **Hidden talent.** A child's strengths can lie unnoticed when adults do not look past stereotypes.
- **Change of attitude.** People can grow; Nana's final acceptance shows that achievement can overturn prejudice.
- **Gender expectations and education.** The story gently argues that girls should be allowed to follow what they are good at.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Child's viewpoint	We see the adults' remarks through Adjoa's hurt, which makes the criticism more painful.
Simple, conversational language	Short sentences and a spoken tone make a serious message easy to follow.
Irony	The legs that were called a weakness win the race.
Repetition	Constant mentions of legs show how the village fixates on appearance.
Local colour	Names, village life and the long school walk root the story in Ghana.
Tone	Warm, gently humorous, and then triumphant.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
Nana says thin legs cannot bear a woman's duties	The prejudice the story challenges.
Adjoa: problems come at different times	A child's wise remark to herself, hinting that thin legs may have their own uses.
the cup for the best junior athlete	The proof that ends the argument.
Nana carrying the cup home	Her pride and change of mind shown through an action.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
Nana	Ghanaian word for grandmother
Maami	mother, in the local usage of the story
spindly	long, thin and weak-looking
district	an area into which a region is divided for administration
representing	speaking or acting on behalf of a group
stereotype	a fixed, over-simple idea about a type of person
fertile	rich and productive
triumph	a great victory

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

Nana was anxious that the girl's legs, so thin that they seemed hardly able to hold her, would never do for the life of a woman in the village.

Q. Who is Nana, and what is she worried about?
Ans. She is Adjoa's grandmother. She fears that thin legs cannot carry loads, farm or support a woman's future role.

Q. What do her remarks show about the village?
Ans. They show that women were judged mainly by their bodies and their usefulness in traditional roles.

Q. How does Adjoa feel?
Ans. She is hurt and embarrassed, withdraws into silence and begins to doubt herself.

Context

Adjoa had always loved running, but she told nobody about her wins at school sports.

Q. Why does Adjoa keep her success secret?
Ans. Nobody at home treats her legs as anything but a problem, so she expects no encouragement. She also fears being mocked.

Q. What does this show about her character?
Ans. She is shy but independent; she finds her own source of confidence in what she can do.

Context

When Adjoa won the cup, her grandmother carried it home, her eyes full of pride.

Q. What had Adjoa won, and where?
Ans. She had won the cup for the best junior athlete at the district sports week.

Q. Why is Nana's action important?
Ans. Carrying the cup is a public sign of pride. It shows that she has dropped her old opinion about Adjoa's legs.

Q. What message does this ending give?
Ans. That talent and effort can change the minds of people who have been critical.

Short Answer Questions

Q. Where is the story set, and who are Adjoa's family?
Ans. In the village of Hasodzi in Ghana. Adjoa lives with her mother Maami and grandmother Nana.

Q. Why was Nana not happy with Adjoa's legs?
Ans. She thought they were too thin to be useful for farm work, carrying loads and having children later.

Q. What was Adjoa's secret?
Ans. She was the fastest runner among her schoolmates, but her family did not know.

Q. How did the family react to the news that she was chosen for the district sports?
Ans. They were surprised; Nana was doubtful, but she helped to get Adjoa ready.

Q. What does the title mean?
Ans. It points to the girl who, despite being written off, can do what others cannot, and it also celebrates what girls can achieve.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe how Adjoa's character develops in the story. (about 150 words)
Ans. At the start Adjoa is a silent seven-year-old who absorbs her grandmother's criticism and feels ashamed of her legs. She watches other women's legs and wonders whether hers could ever be right. But she has an inner strength: she loves school, walks a long way to reach it, and trains herself without knowing it, so that she beats

everyone at running. Her talent grows in secret. When she is selected for the district sports she proves herself in the best possible way, by winning. By the end she is no longer ashamed; she has self-respect and the approval of her family. The story shows her growth from shyness to quiet confidence.

Q. How does Aidoo show a conflict between tradition and change? (about 150 words)
Ans. Nana represents tradition: women must be physically strong for farm work and motherhood, and appearance is judged by this standard. Adjoa represents change: she goes to school, enters races, and finds worth in a new way. The conflict is not shouted; it plays out in remarks, silences and a race. The result is that tradition gives way when faced with proof. Nana does not abandon her love for her granddaughter; she revises her ideas. Aidoo suggests that customs should not block a child's abilities and that families can change if they are willing to look at the facts.

HOT Questions

- Do you think Nana is a villain? Defend your answer using her words and actions.
- Why might Aidoo have chosen a seven-year-old as the central character and not an adult?
- Adjoa won through action, not argument. Is that always the best way to answer criticism?
- What are some 'thin legs' in your own world, things people judge you for that may be a strength?

Quick Recap

- Writer: Ama Ata Aidoo, Ghanaian author and former Minister of Education.
- Plot: Nana's worry, Adjoa's silence, a secret talent, selection for district sports, a winning race, Nana's change of heart.
- Themes: tradition vs talent, self-worth, gender expectation, change of attitude.
- Devices: child's viewpoint, irony, simple spoken style. Tone: warm and triumphant.

04

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

The Pedestrian

In 2053 everyone is glued to a screen, and one man still likes to walk. Bradbury shows how a harmless habit can look like a crime.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Ray Bradbury
- Science fiction
- Technology and isolation
- Individual vs state
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Ray Bradbury (1920 to 2012) was an American writer of science fiction and fantasy, best known for *Fahrenheit 451* and *The Martian Chronicles*. He often warned that technology, used carelessly, could make people passive and shut out books, nature and thought. "The Pedestrian" was written in 1951 and imagines the year **2053**.

Bradbury himself liked to walk at night, and was once stopped by a police officer who could not understand why anyone would stroll without a purpose. That incident is said to have inspired this story.



KEY POINT

Setting: a quiet American city, an evening in November 2053. The streets are empty because almost everyone is indoors, watching television.

Story in Six Steps

1. 1. The evening walk

Leonard Mead steps out into a silent city on a cold November evening, as he does most nights. The pavements are cracked and empty, and the houses are dark tombs lit only by the grey flicker of television screens.

2. 2. The lonely habit

Mead has walked for years and never meets another person. He enjoys the quiet, imagines the viewers as ghosts behind the windows, and has no fear.

3. 3. The car

A police car with no driver appears and a metallic voice orders him to stand still. It is the city's only police vehicle, as crime has almost vanished.

4. 4. The questions

The machine asks his name and job. Mead says he is a writer, but nobody reads any more. He has no television and no wife. It cannot accept that he walks simply to breathe and look.

5. 5. The charge

It records him as a man with 'regressive tendencies'. Mead is ordered into the back of the car, which is a small cage with no handle.

6. 6. The end

The car carries him to the Psychiatric Center for Research on Regressive Tendencies. Behind him, his own house stands bright and warm, the only lit house in the street, with nobody home.

Characters

CHARACTER	TRAITS
Leonard Mead	A solitary writer; curious, calm and independent. He values fresh air and the real world, which makes him an outsider.
The police car	A cold, programmed machine with no empathy; it stands for the state and for technology without judgement.
The unseen citizens	Faceless people hidden behind screens; they have given up conversation, thought and nature.

Themes and Messages

- **Technology and isolation.** Television has replaced conversation and community.
- **Individual vs the state.** Doing something different is treated as a sickness or crime.
- **Loss of curiosity and free thought.** Reading, writing and walking are dying habits.
- **Warning to the reader.** Bradbury asks us to value nature, books and each other before it is too late.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Imagery	Sights and sounds such as the 'gray phosphorescence' of screens and the silent street, which make the future frozen and lifeless.
Simile and metaphor	Houses are compared to tombs and viewers to ghosts, showing that the people are alive in body but dead in spirit.
Irony	The only truly 'normal' human behaviour is treated as abnormal. The one house with lights on is the man's, and it is empty.
Personification	The car speaks in a flat, mechanical voice, showing a machine as the ruler.
Dystopian setting	A future that looks calm on the outside but has lost freedom.
Tone	Quiet, eerie and sad, with grim humour.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
"the only pedestrian"	Walking has become so rare that Mead is the sole person doing it.
houses like tombs	Life has gone out of the community.
"No profession"	The machine's logic: a writer in a world without readers does not count.
"regressive tendencies"	A fancy label that turns a human habit into a mental illness.
his own lit house	A last bitter picture: the only warmth in the street is empty because the owner is taken.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
pedestrian	a person walking on the road, not driving
phosphorescence	a soft glow of light
regressive	going back to an older, less advanced way
tombs	graves or burial chambers
sidewalk	pavement beside a road
hiss	a long ‘s’ sound like air escaping
dystopia	an imagined society where life is unpleasant and controlled
psychiatric	relating to treatment of mental illness

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

Mead walked on through the cold evening, looking at the houses that glowed faintly like graves.

Q. Where and when is the story set?
Ans. It is set in a city in the year 2053, in November, on a quiet evening.

Q. Why does the writer compare houses to tombs?
Ans. The people inside sit still, silent and glued to screens. They seem dead to the world even though they are alive.

Q. What does this tell you about the society?
Ans. It is a society where people have given up conversation and action for entertainment.

Context

A voice from the stranger car asked him what he was doing, and Mead replied that he was only walking.

Q. Who is questioning Mead, and what is unusual about it?
Ans. The questioner is an empty police car, run by a machine. It has no driver, which shows how fully machines have taken over.

Q. Why does the voice fail to understand him?
Ans. In its world, nobody walks for pleasure, so it can only see his behaviour as suspicious.

Q. What does the incident say about the state?
Ans. That it values conformity, and treats difference as a danger.

Context

The car sped away, leaving the street empty, except for a single house with light in every window.

Q. Whose house is this?
Ans. It is Leonard Mead's home.

Q. Why is the lit house ironic?
Ans. The only house that looks full of life is empty, because the one man who lived freely has been taken away.

Q. What feeling does the ending leave?
Ans. Sadness and unease; it warns us how easily freedom can vanish.

Short Answer Questions

Q. Why does Leonard Mead like to walk in the evening?
Ans. He enjoys the cool air, the quiet and the chance to observe the world with his own eyes, without noise.

Q. Why does the police car stop him?
Ans. Because it finds a lone man walking aimlessly at night very suspicious in a city where everyone stays home.

Q. What does Mead say his profession is?
Ans. He says he is a writer, but the machine replies that this is no profession as nobody reads.

Q. Where is Mead taken at the end?
Ans. To the Psychiatric Center for Research on Regressive Tendencies.

Q. What warning does Bradbury give?
Ans. That excessive dependence on technology and screens may rob us of freedom, curiosity and human contact.

Long Answer Questions

Q. How does Bradbury present a future in which technology rules? (about 150 words)
Ans. Bradbury paints a calm, orderly city whose calm hides a loss of life. The streets are empty because everyone watches television. There is almost no crime, so there is only one police car, and it is run by a machine with no human feeling. Houses are compared to tombs, and people are compared to ghosts. The machine cannot see walking as anything but strange, and treats the lone walker as mentally unwell. Books are gone, the writer has no readers, and individuality is nearly extinct. Through these details Bradbury shows how technology, left unchecked, can produce a world of isolation, obedience and silence.

Q. Write a character sketch of Leonard Mead. (about 150 words)
Ans. Leonard Mead is a quiet, thoughtful writer who prefers the real world to the screen. He walks every evening for fresh air and company with his own thoughts. He is calm and polite, even when the police car questions him, and he answers honestly with no attempt to hide. He is brave in his own way: he does not conform to the habits of his neighbours. He is also lonely, with no wife, no friend and no audience. Yet he is not unhappy. His weakness is that he cannot defend himself against a machine that does not understand. His fate makes him a symbol of every individual crushed by an unthinking system.

HOT Questions

- Do you think the world Bradbury imagined is closer today than in 1951? Which details feel familiar?
- Mead is arrested for doing nothing. Is a society that cannot tolerate harmless difference truly safe?
- Why might Bradbury have used a driverless police car, not a human policeman?
- How would the story change if even one other pedestrian had appeared?

Quick Recap

- Writer: Ray Bradbury. Year of writing 1951, set in 2053.
- Plot: Mead’s walk, the empty city, the police car’s questions, the arrest, the lit empty house.
- Themes: technology and isolation, individual vs state, loss of curiosity.
- Devices: imagery, simile, irony, personification. Tone: eerie and sad.

05

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

The Last Lesson

On a bright spring morning a lazy schoolboy discovers that today is his last French lesson. In a few hours he learns what his language and country are worth.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Alphonse Daudet
- Franco-Prussian War
- Love of language
- Patriotism
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Alphonse Daudet (1840 to 1897) was a French novelist and short-story writer. “The Last Lesson” comes from his collection *Contes du lundi* (Monday Tales), written after France lost the **Franco-Prussian War of 1870 to 1871**.

As a result of that war France gave up the border regions of **Alsace and Lorraine** to Prussia. The Prussian rulers ordered that only German be taught in schools there. The story is told by **Franz**, a young boy, looking back on the morning when French was taught for the last time.



REAL LIFE

Think of it this way: imagine that tomorrow your school could teach only in a language that is not yours. How much would you suddenly value your own?

Story in Seven Steps

1. 1. A late and careless boy

Franz sets off for school late, unprepared for the grammar test on participles. The day is warm and tempting, and he would rather play truant. He still decides to go.

2. 2. A strange notice

He passes the town hall, where a crowd stands before the bulletin board. The blacksmith, Wachter, tells him to take his time, as he will get there soon enough. Franz thinks he is teasing.

3. 3. A strangely quiet class

At school it is unusually silent. M. Hamel is not angry; he speaks gently, wears his best clothes, and the back benches hold the village elders, including old Hauser, with their primers.

4. 4. The announcement

M. Hamel says that orders have come from Berlin: only German will be taught in Alsace and Lorraine. This is the last lesson in French. Franz is stunned and ashamed at how little he knows.

5. 5. The teacher’s confession

M. Hamel blames not only the boys and their parents but also himself, for not caring enough about teaching. He praises French as the clearest and most logical of languages and says it must be guarded, because a people who keep their language hold the key to their prison.

6. 6. A quiet, serious lesson

Everyone listens as never before, including the old men who spell out letters in shaky voices. Franz finds that the lesson he thought hard is simple now. He wishes he had learned earlier.

7. 7. “Vive la France!”

The church clock strikes twelve and the Prussian bugles sound. M. Hamel, pale, tries to speak but can only write on the board ‘Vive la France!’ He dismisses the class with a wave of the hand.

Characters

CHARACTER	TRAITS
Franz	A playful, careless schoolboy. He grows up in a morning: regret and love of his language wake in him.
M. Hamel	Dedicated, stern and sad. His dress shows respect for the occasion; his speech shows courage and guilt. His emotion shows how deeply he loves his country.
Old Hauser and the villagers	They come to the class to honour the language they neglected, and show regret that they did not learn when they could.
Wachter the blacksmith	A passing figure whose odd remark hints at the notice that Franz has not yet understood.

Themes and Messages

- **Love for one's language.** Language is part of identity and freedom.
- **Patriotism and resistance.** Silent grief and a chalked slogan show a nation's pride in defeat.
- **Regret and lost chances.** People value education only when it is about to be taken away.
- **Education and responsibility.** M. Hamel and the parents accept their share of blame for putting off learning.
- **Cultural domination.** A conqueror often tries to control language to control people.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Simple, moving narrative	A child narrator keeps the language plain, so the emotion feels honest.
Contrast	Franz's carefree walk against the grave mood of the classroom.
Foreshadowing	The crowd at the town hall and Wachter's words hint at the news.
Symbolism	The chalked 'Vive la France!' and the bugles stand for national spirit and foreign power.
Irony	Franz finds the lesson easy only when it is too late.
Tone	Bright and playful at first, becoming solemn and sorrowful.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
the key to prison	M. Hamel's idea that keeping one's language keeps hope of freedom.
the clearest, most logical language	His pride in French.
"Vive la France!"	The teacher's last, wordless act of love for his country.
the elders on the back benches	Even grown men came to show respect and regret.
Franz's thought about pigeons	A sad thought: will they now have to coo in German too?

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
participle	a verb form used as an adjective or in compound tenses
truant	a pupil who stays away from school without leave
bulletin board	a board for public notices
primer	a first reading book for children
Prussians	the people of the German state that conquered France in 1871
reproach	blame or disapproval
solemn	serious and dignified
dismiss	to send away

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

'Franz, you should have been on time. It is a great pity,' said the master gently; 'now sit down quickly.'

Q. Who is speaking, and to whom?
Ans. M. Hamel, the French teacher, is speaking to Franz, who arrives late.

Q. Why is Franz surprised by the reaction?
Ans. He had expected a harsh scolding for being late and not knowing his lesson, but the teacher is calm and kind.

Q. What does the reaction hint at?
Ans. That something serious has happened, and this is not a normal school day.

Context

The teacher said that French was the most beautiful, clearest and most logical language in the world, and they must guard it.

Q. Why does M. Hamel speak so emotionally about French?
Ans. He knows it is the last day it will be taught in the school, and he wants his pupils to hold on to it.

Q. What does he mean when he calls a language a 'key'?
Ans. As long as a conquered people keep their own language, they keep a link to their freedom and identity.

Q. Does the teacher blame only others?
Ans. No. He also admits his own failings, such as sending pupils to water his plants and taking a holiday to fish.

Context

The church clock struck twelve and then the Angelus; at that moment the trumpets of the Prussians returning from drill sounded under the windows.

Q. Why is this moment important?
Ans. It marks the end of the final lesson, with the conqueror's trumpets arriving in the middle of the school.

Q. What does M. Hamel do next?
Ans. He is too moved to speak. He writes 'Vive la France!' on the blackboard and dismisses the class.

Q. What does this show about him?
Ans. It shows his deep patriotism and his sorrow at losing the French language in school.

Short Answer Questions

Q. Why did Franz not want to go to school?
Ans. He had not learned his lesson on participles and the weather outside was tempting.

Q. What was the news on the bulletin board?
Ans. The order from Berlin that German alone would be taught in the schools of Alsace and Lorraine.

Q. Why were the villagers sitting at the back of the class?
Ans. They wanted to show respect for M. Hamel and the French language, and to make up for the education they had neglected.

Q. What did M. Hamel write at the end?
Ans. 'Vive la France!'

Q. How did Franz change during the lesson?
Ans. He regretted his past idleness and began to value his language and his teacher.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe how the character of Franz changes in the story. (about 150 words)
Ans. At the beginning Franz is a playful boy who dislikes school and would rather hunt birds or play outdoors. He is afraid of a scolding for being late. When he hears the news of the last lesson, he feels shocked and ashamed. He sees how little he has learned, and he suddenly understands the value of what he took for granted. By the end he listens attentively, finds the grammar easy, and is moved by his teacher and the old men. He even wonders how a language can be taken away. In one morning Franz moves from carelessness to maturity and a love of his own tongue.

Q. What does the story tell us about the importance of one's mother tongue? (about 150 words)
Ans. Daudet shows that language is more than a school subject; it is part of our identity and freedom. When the Prussians forbid French, the villagers feel they are losing their country's soul. M. Hamel says that a people who hold on to their language have the key to their prison, meaning that cultural pride keeps hope alive. The regret of Franz and the elders warns us not to postpone learning our language till it is threatened. The final slogan on the blackboard says what words cannot: that loyalty to language is loyalty to one's nation.

HOT Questions

- Is M. Hamel right to blame himself and the parents? Who is most responsible for the neglect of French?
- Why might conquerors want to change the language of the people they rule?
- Imagine a version of the story told by M. Hamel. How would the emotional centre change?
- Do modern students ever treat their own languages carelessly? Give examples and suggest what can be done.

Quick Recap

- Writer: Alphonse Daudet, French. Set in Alsace after the Franco-Prussian War.
- Plot: Franz is late, the strange calm, the order from Berlin, Hamel's speech, 'Vive la France!'
- Themes: love of language, patriotism, regret, education.
- Devices: child narrator, contrast, foreshadowing, symbolism. Tone: playful, then solemn.

06

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

Haunted Houses

Longfellow says every home where people have lived is full of unseen visitors. The poem is less about scary ghosts than about the quiet bond between the living and the dead.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- H. W. Longfellow
- Ghosts and memory
- Spirit world
- Imagery
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow (1807 to 1882) was one of the best known American poets of the nineteenth century, famous for narrative and lyrical poems such as *The Song of Hiawatha*. "Haunted Houses" (published in 1858) belongs to his reflective, spiritual poems.

The poem is written in **ten stanzas of four lines**, with a steady rhyme. The speaker speaks in a calm, thoughtful voice and does not try to scare us. The ghosts here are gentle, harmless presences.



KEY POINT

Central idea: the world of spirits is close to the world we know; the dead do not leave us completely, and they influence our lives in ways we can feel but cannot see.

Stanza-by-Stanza Summary

1. Stanza 1

Every house in which people have lived and died is haunted. Harmless ghosts glide through the open doors on their own errands, and their feet make no sound on the floors.

2. Stanza 2

We meet these presences at doorways, on staircases and in passages. They are not seen, only felt: a faint sense of something moving to and fro in the air.

3. Stanza 3

At dinner there are more guests than the host invited. The lit hall is crowded with quiet, gentle ghosts who are as still as the portraits on the wall.

4. Stanza 4

A visitor at the fireside sees only what is present. The speaker, who knows the house, sees all that has ever happened there, clear and bright.

5. Stanza 5

Nobody truly owns a house or land. Earlier owners reach out from forgotten graves and still hold on to their old estates, so the present occupants are only borrowers.

6. Stanza 6

The spirit-world surrounds this world of the senses like an atmosphere, and a breath of finer air blows through our heavy earthly mists.

7. Stanza 7

Our small lives are balanced between two pulls: the instinct to enjoy bodily pleasures and the nobler instinct to aspire.

8. Stanzas 8 and 9

This constant strain between wants and ideals comes from the influence of an unseen star, like an undiscovered planet that disturbs the sky. As the moon throws a bridge of light across the sea, so our imagination crowds on to a path into the realm of mystery.

9. Stanza 10

In the same way a bridge of light comes down from the spirit-world to ours. Our thoughts wander over its swaying floor above the dark gulf between the two.

Speaker and Tone

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Speaker	A thoughtful, calm observer who believes in a spirit-world and speaks quietly, like a philosopher by the fireside.
Addressed to	The general reader, as if inviting us to think.
Mood	Peaceful, reflective, slightly mysterious; there is wonder but no horror.
Structure	Starts with a concrete picture of houses and ghosts, then widens into a view of the universe.

Themes and Messages

- **The living and the dead are linked.** Memory and spirit continue in the places where people lived.
- **The unseen world is real.** The poet suggests a life beyond what our five senses tell us.
- **Human conflict.** We are pulled between low desires and noble aspirations.
- **Hope and comfort.** Death is not an end but a doorway; a bridge of light connects both worlds.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Personification	Ghosts are described as guests who move and sit like living visitors, which makes them feel familiar.
Simile	The moon's bridge of light compared with the link between spirit and living worlds.
Metaphor	The 'unseen star' stands for the unseen cause of our inner struggle; the 'atmosphere' stands for the spirit-world.
Alliteration and sound	Soft repeated sounds in the early stanzas give a hushed, whispering effect.
Imagery	Pictures of dark halls, stairs, fire and the moonlit sea.
Rhyme scheme	Regular abab rhyme gives a calm, steady flow.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
houses ‘haunted’ by those who lived and died	The poem’s opening claim: every home has a past.
more guests than the host invited	The ghosts are quiet visitors, as still as portraits, not monsters.
owners from forgotten graves	The dead still ‘hold’ the estates; the living are only temporary occupants.
“spirit-world around this world of sense”	An atmosphere of the spiritual all around the physical.
“opposite attractions and desires”	Our lives are balanced between pleasure and higher goals.
bridge of light	The link between the two worlds, shown through a moonlit sea.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
phantom	a ghost or spirit
impalpable	that cannot be felt by touch
ethereal	delicate and heavenly
equipoise	balance
perturbation	a disturbance
aspire	to hope strongly to achieve something high
abyss	a deep gulf
fancy	imagination

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

All houses wherein men have lived and died are haunted houses; through the open doors the harmless phantoms on their errands glide.

Q. Who are the ‘phantoms’, and what are they doing?
Ans. They are the spirits of those who once lived and died in the houses. They glide quietly through the rooms, as if going about their business.

Q. Why does the poet call them harmless?
Ans. They do not frighten or harm anyone; they simply share the house with the living.

Q. What is the poet’s attitude to ghosts?
Ans. Calm and accepting; he treats them as natural neighbours, not as terrors.

Context

The spirit-world around this world of sense floats like an atmosphere, and everywhere wafts through these earthly mists a breath of finer air.

Q. What is the ‘world of sense’?
Ans. It is the material world we know through sight, touch and hearing.

Q. What does the poet compare the spirit-world to?
Ans. To the air around the earth, which is invisible but surrounds everything.

Q. What does this suggest about human life?
Ans. That there is a finer, spiritual reality close to our own, which touches us even though we do not see it.

Context

As the moon from some dark gate of cloud throws o’er the sea a floating bridge of light, so does the spirit-world send a bridge to ours.

Q. What picture does the poet draw here?
Ans. The moon, coming out from behind a dark cloud, casts a path of light across the water.

Q. What does this bridge stand for?
Ans. The link by which our thoughts may cross towards the world of spirits.

Q. How does this image end the poem?
Ans. It leaves us with hope and wonder, suggesting that the two worlds are joined, not divided.

Short Answer Questions

Q. What is the central idea of ‘Haunted Houses’?
Ans. The spirit-world is close to ours. The dead remain with us in memory and presence, and our own inner struggle is connected with it.

Q. How are the ghosts described?
Ans. As harmless, silent guests who pass through doors and halls and sit near the fire.

Q. What two forces pull at human life?
Ans. The pull of bodily desires and the pull of higher, nobler aspirations.

Q. What does the ‘unseen star’ stand for?
Ans. It stands for an invisible source of the tugs and strains in human life, as an unknown planet may disturb the paths of the known ones.

Q. What is the effect of the final image?
Ans. The bridge of light gives a hopeful close, linking two worlds and soothing the fear of death.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Explain how Longfellow presents the presence of the dead in our lives. (about 150 words)
Ans. Longfellow suggests that people who have lived and died in a house never altogether leave it. In the early stanzas, their spirits glide through halls and passages, crowd the dining hall, and share the space with us. They are not frightening; they are silent, familiar guests. Later he widens the idea: the spirit-world surrounds ours like air, and the strain between our desires and aspirations comes from an unseen star. The poem ends with a bridge of light between the two worlds. The poet's message is gentle: the dead are present through memory and spirit, and we should feel peace, not terror, in their company.

Q. Discuss the use of imagery in 'Haunted Houses'. (about 150 words)
Ans. The poem moves from small, domestic images to vast ones. At first we see houses, doors, halls, stairs and the dinner table, which are everyday settings made mysterious by invisible visitors. Then the poet turns to the sky: an atmosphere of finer air, a star never seen, and a planet unknown. The final image is of the moon lighting a path across a dark sea. These pictures are mostly visual and soft; they create quiet wonder, not fear. The movement from home to heavens suits the poem's idea that the spiritual world is both near and vast.

HOT Questions

- Why do you think Longfellow chose gentle ghosts, not terrifying ones? What does this say about his view of death?
- Does the poem prove that spirits exist, or does it only describe a feeling? Discuss.
- How can a place hold the memory of those who lived there? Give an example from your own experience.
- Compare the spirit-world idea in this poem with the way When Great Trees Fall treats the dead.

Quick Recap

- Poet: H. W. Longfellow, American. Ten quatrains.
- Idea: the living and the unseen world are joined; ghosts are harmless guests.
- Key images: silent guests, atmosphere, unseen star, bridge of light.
- Devices: personification, metaphor, simile, imagery. Tone: calm and reflective.

07

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

The Glove and the Lions

A lady tests her admirer's love with a deadly dare, and he answers in a way nobody in the royal gallery expects. A story-poem about true love and false show.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Leigh Hunt
- Narrative poem
- King Francis
- Love vs vanity
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Leigh Hunt (1784 to 1859) was an English poet, essayist and critic, and a friend of Keats and Shelley. "The Glove and the Lions" (1836) is a **narrative poem** built on an old story told about King Francis I of France, who held court in the sixteenth century.

In the poem the king and his nobles and ladies sit in a gallery above an enclosure where lions were kept. Watching wild beasts was a favourite entertainment, and the poem begins in this setting of splendour and cruelty.



KEY POINT

The poem is told in the third person by a narrator who describes events briskly, then lets the Count's own words deliver the moral.

Summary of the Story

1. The scene
King Francis and his court gather to watch the lions. The king's manner is easy and jovial, and the ladies, among them a famed beauty, are seated beside the nobles.

2. The fight
The lions, awakened, begin to prowl and then fight. The narrator describes the savage roaring, the clash of paws and the foam. The crowd looks on, thrilled, from safety.

3. The dare
In the middle of the din, a lady drops her glove into the arena. She turns to the Count de Lorge, who loves her, and says that if he truly loves her he will bring it back.

4. The Count's act
De Lorge bows, walks calmly down into the pit, stops in the middle of the animals, picks up the glove and returns just as calmly. The crowd is stunned.

5. The rejection
He goes up to the lady and, instead of handing it over, throws the glove in her face. He tells her that she did not want his love, only proof of her power, and he walks away.

6. The verdict
King Francis, who has watched everything, openly sides with the Count. The lady has lost both a lover and her pride.

Characters

CHARACTER	TRAITS
King Francis	Cheerful, observant and fair-minded. He enjoys spectacle but recognises true courage and the lady's cruelty.
Count de Lorge	Brave, calm and dignified, with self-respect. He proves his courage and refuses to be treated as a toy.
The lady	Beautiful but vain and thoughtless. She risks a man's life only to test her power and show off.
The court	Eager spectators who enjoy danger when it is someone else's.

Themes and Messages

- **True love vs show.** The lady wants proof that others will notice; the Count shows that real love needs respect.
- **Courage with dignity.** The Count's bravery lies as much in his cool retort as in entering the pit.
- **Vanity and cruelty.** The lady's game exposes vanity and carelessness for another's life.
- **Self-respect.** A person who loves should not lose their dignity to a test of this kind.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Narrative style	A swift story told in rhymed couplets, full of action and direct speech.
Description of the lions	Vivid sounds and images (roaring, rolling, claws) create excitement and fear.
Irony	A court that applauds cruelty is shocked by the Count's boldness; the lady who wanted to humble him is humbled.
Climax	The throwing of the glove is the turning point.
Contrast	The cool, quiet Count and the savage beasts; the lady's smile and her heartless motive.
Tone	Lively and dramatic at the start, then serious and moral.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
"No love, but vanity"	The Count's reply, summing up the poem's message in a few words.
the lady's glove in the den	A cruel symbol of vanity.
the Count's cool walk	True courage is calm and controlled.
King Francis's approval	The king recognises the moral meaning of the act.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
jovial	cheerful and friendly
lists	an enclosed place for combat
gallery	a raised balcony for spectators
roar	the loud, deep cry of a lion
cavalier	a gallant gentleman, here a gentleman-knight
vanity	excessive pride in oneself
fawning	behaving in a servile, flattering way
quoth	an old word meaning ‘said’

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

The lady dropped her glove into the arena and turned to her admirer, saying that if he loved her as he claimed, he would go and get it.

Q. Who is the lady and who is her admirer?
Ans. She is a beautiful lady of King Francis’s court, and her admirer is the Count de Lorge.

Q. Why does the lady drop the glove?
Ans. She wants to test how far the Count’s love will go, and to enjoy her power and the attention of the court.

Q. What does this show about her?
Ans. That she is vain, thoughtless and willing to risk a life for a moment of amusement.

Context

De Lorge went down among the lions, took up the glove and came back as calmly as he had gone.

Q. What qualities does De Lorge show?
Ans. Great courage and presence of mind, as he faces savage animals without panic.

Q. What is the crowd’s reaction?
Ans. They are amazed and relieved, and watch him with admiration.

Q. What does he do next?
Ans. He throws the glove in the lady’s face and rejects her.

Context

'No love,' the Count told her, 'but vanity sets love a task like that.'

Q. What does the Count mean?
Ans. He means that real love would never put the beloved in danger for a trifle. Only vanity and the wish to display power would do so.

Q. Why is this the climax of the poem?
Ans. It reveals the moral and reverses the situation: the tested lover judges the tester.

Q. How does the king respond?
Ans. King Francis supports the Count, showing that the court values honour over show.

Short Answer Questions

Q. Where does the poem begin and who is present?
Ans. In a gallery overlooking the lions' den, where King Francis, his nobles and his ladies watch the beasts.

Q. What was the lady's test?
Ans. She dropped her glove into the arena and asked the Count to bring it back as proof of his love.

Q. Why did De Lorge throw the glove at the lady's face?
Ans. He was disgusted that she had risked his life merely to show off her power, and he wanted to show her what true love is.

Q. What does the lion's fight add to the poem?
Ans. It builds danger and excitement and sets up the contrast between brute violence and human courage and dignity.

Q. What is the moral of the poem?
Ans. Genuine love is not a show, and those who treat others as playthings lose both love and respect.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Narrate the incident of the glove from the Count's point of view. (about 150 words)
Ans. I was seated in the gallery beside the king when the lions began to fight below. The noise was fearful. Then the lady I loved dropped her glove into the arena and smiled at me, as if I were a toy. She said that a true lover would bring it back. I knew she cared less for my life than for the entertainment. Yet I would not refuse. I went down, passed the beasts without hurry, took up the glove and returned. Before the whole court I threw it in her face. Her love, if it was love, was only vanity. Having proved my courage, I now proved that I had self-respect.

Q. Do you think the lady deserved the Count's response? Give reasons. (about 150 words)
Ans. Yes, the lady deserved it. Her test was cruel and selfish. She did not need the glove; she merely wanted to see her admirer risk his life before the court so that her charm would be admired. Her action shows vanity and disregard for human life. A true lover would never expose the other to such danger. The Count's refusal to go on serving her was therefore justified, and his act of throwing the glove in her face was a fair rebuke. The poem's message is that love and honour cannot be won by cruelty or show, and that those who play with another's life must expect to be judged.

HOT Questions

- Was the Count wise to risk his life, even if he intended to reject the lady afterwards? Defend your opinion.
- Why does Hunt show the king and court enjoying the lion fight? What does it suggest about them?
- Imagine the lady's reply to the Count. What might she say, and would it change anything?
- Does true love require proofs? Discuss using the poem.

Quick Recap

- Poet: Leigh Hunt, English Romantic-era writer. Narrative poem, 1836.
- Story: lions fight, lady drops glove, the Count retrieves it, throws it back, king approves.
- Themes: true love vs vanity, courage, self-respect.
- Devices: narrative, vivid description, irony, contrast. Tone: dramatic, then moral.

08

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

When Great Trees Fall

The fall of a great tree shakes the forest, and the death of a great person shakes us. Angelou follows the shock, the long silence and the gift they leave behind.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Maya Angelou
- Grief and memory
- Nature imagery
- Free verse
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Maya Angelou (1928 to 2014) was an American poet, memoirist and civil-rights activist, best known for her autobiography *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings*. Her work explores courage, dignity, loss and hope, often in a rhythmic, speaking voice.

This poem is in **free verse** (no regular rhyme). It begins with the fall of great trees in the forest and ends with the death of great souls, using one as a metaphor for the other. The speaker is a mourner and a witness, and the voice is solemn and tender.



FUN FACT

Notice the pattern: nature's reaction in the first two sections, then the human reaction in the last. The poem is one long comparison.

Section-by-Section Summary

1. Section 1: the tremor

When a great tree falls, even far-off rocks shudder. Lions in the long grass lie low, and elephants are unsteady on their feet. The loss of something huge disturbs every creature, from the strong to the unsure.

2. Section 2: the silence

In the forest, when the great trees fall, smaller creatures draw back into a silence. Their senses are numbed, beyond fear, and the air grows heavy and still.

3. Section 3: great souls

When great souls die, a period of grief follows. Peace later returns, slowly and unevenly, filling the empty spaces. Our senses grow sharper and the loss changes us; we are told that these people lived, so we too can be, and be better.

Speaker and Tone

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Speaker	A mourner who has lost a respected figure, speaking for all who feel such losses.
Mood	Starts with shock and fear, moves through silence to peace, and ends in hope.
Structure	Three parts: a natural shock, a hush, and a human comfort.
Form	Free verse with uneven lines, close to everyday speech.

Themes and Messages

- **Impact of great people.** Their death shakes everyone around them, as a falling tree shakes a forest.
- **The process of grief.** Shock, hush, slow recovery and a new understanding.

- **Legacy.** Those who have gone leave an example that helps the living become better.
- **Link between humans and nature.** Human grief is part of a wider natural order.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Extended metaphor	Great trees stand for great souls throughout the poem.
Personification	Rocks that shudder, lions that hide and small creatures that retreat feel like grieving beings.
Imagery	Strong visual and sound pictures: the shuddering rocks, the crouching animals, the heavy silence.
Contrast	Mighty creatures like lions and elephants are shaken, while the smallest are silenced.
Repetition	The phrase ‘they existed’ at the end drives home the message of legacy.
Tone	Solemn, then consoling and uplifting.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
“When great trees fall”	The opening image of a shaking forest.
“great souls die”	The turn from nature to human loss.
“never to be the same”	Grief changes us permanently.
“They existed”	The poem’s comfort: a life was lived, and the example lives.
“Be and be better”	The final call to the living.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
recoil	to spring back in shock
hunker	to crouch low
unsteady	not firm or steady
numb	unable to feel
irregularly	not in a regular or even way
resonance	a lasting echo of sound or feeling
legacy	what a person leaves behind for others
solace	comfort in sorrow

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

The poem opens with the great trees falling, and rocks on distant hills ‘shudder’ while lions and elephants are shaken.

Q. What event is described in these lines?
Ans. The falling of a great tree, and the effect it has on the whole landscape.

Q. Why are the lions and elephants mentioned?
Ans. They are among the strongest creatures. If they are shaken, the effect must be enormous.

Q. What does this suggest about the loss of a great person?
Ans. It shakes the strong as well as the weak, and spreads far beyond those closest to the person.

Context

In the second part, small creatures ‘recoil into silence’ when great trees fall in the forest.

Q. What do ‘small things’ stand for?
Ans. They stand for ordinary people, who feel the loss most deeply.

Q. What does ‘beyond fear’ mean here?
Ans. That the shock is so deep that people go numb and cannot even feel terror.

Q. What mood is created?
Ans. A still, heavy mood of mourning.

Context

In the last part, after great souls die, ‘peace blooms’, but only slowly and unevenly.

Q. What does ‘peace blooms’ mean?
Ans. Calm returns after grief as a flower grows after rain.

Q. Why does the poet use ‘slowly and irregularly’?
Ans. Healing is not even; some days are better than others.

Q. What comfort does the poem end with?
Ans. That those who have died existed, and their example helps us to be and to be better.

Short Answer Questions

Q. What is the central idea of the poem?
Ans. The loss of a great person shakes all of us, but their memory brings peace and inspires us to live better.

Q. What happens to creatures when a great tree falls?
Ans. The rocks shudder, lions crouch, elephants lose balance, and small creatures are struck silent.

Q. What is the effect of the death of great souls on the living?
Ans. At first they are stunned, then peace returns slowly, and the survivors are changed for good.

Q. What does the repetition of ‘they existed’ suggest?
Ans. That the fact of their life is itself a gift and a proof of what humans can be.

Q. What is the tone of the poem’s ending?
Ans. Hopeful and encouraging; it urges us to take heart from those who lived greatly.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Explain how Angelou compares the fall of great trees with the death of great souls. (about 150 words)
Ans. Angelou uses the falling tree as an extended metaphor. First she shows how nature responds: rocks shudder, lions crouch, elephants stumble and smaller creatures go silent. This conveys shock spreading outwards. In the last section she says the same happens when great souls die. After the shock, a slow peace returns and the empty space is filled with a kind of gentle hum. Our senses are changed and nothing is quite as before. The comparison suggests that great people are as important to the human world as great trees are to the forest, and their loss is felt widely.

Q. What message does the poem give about death and memory? (about 150 words)
Ans. The poem says that death of a great person is a heavy blow, but not the end of their influence. After the first shock and silence, peace comes, and with it a new awareness. The poet repeats that these people existed, meaning that their lives prove what human beings can achieve. We are therefore encouraged to be and to be better. In this way grief becomes a source of inspiration. The poem consoles by showing that memory is a living force, and that the best answer to loss is to carry forward the qualities of those we admire.

HOT Questions

- Why does Angelou choose trees, not mountains or rivers, as the central image?
- Is the poem about one person or about many? Defend your reading.

- How does the lack of rhyme and regular rhythm affect the poem's feeling?
- Think of a leader or elder whose loss was strongly felt. How does the poem help you describe that feeling?

Quick Recap

- Poet: Maya Angelou, American poet and activist. Free verse.
- Idea: death of great souls shakes us like a falling tree, then leaves peace and inspiration.
- Key lines: 'when great trees fall', 'great souls die', 'they existed', 'be and be better'.
- Devices: extended metaphor, personification, contrast, repetition. Tone: solemn, then hopeful.

09

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

A Considerable Speck

A poet is about to flatten a speck on his page, then notices it moves with purpose. Frost turns a tiny mite into a lesson about mind, respect and mercy.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Robert Frost
- Mind and consciousness
- Mercy
- Irony and humour
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Robert Frost (1874 to 1963) was an American poet, known for rural New England settings and plain speech that hide deep thought. He won four Pulitzer Prizes. “A Considerable Speck” was published in 1942, in the middle of the Second World War, which matters for its closing thought.

The poem is written in a light, conversational voice by a speaker who is Frost himself or a person very like him. A very small event, a speck on a white sheet, leads to a large idea.



KEY POINT

The title is a joke with a point. ‘Considerable’ means both ‘fairly large’ and ‘worth considering’. A speck becomes important because it has a mind.

Summary

1. 1. The speck

The poet is writing on a sheet of white paper when a tiny dark spot starts to move across it. He lifts his pen to crush it with an ink-stroke.

2. 2. The surprise

He then notices that the speck stops, pauses, changes direction and seems to be thinking. It is a living mite and not a particle of dust.

3. 3. The mite’s reaction

As ink spreads, the mite avoids the wet patches, backs away and hunts for another way, plainly afraid of the dangerous fluid and the huge, looming pen.

4. 4. Mercy

The poet puts down the idea of killing it. He says that he has a mind himself and recognises mind wherever he meets it, in any form.

5. 5. The closing thought

He says nobody can know how glad he is to find a trace of mind on any sheet. In a world full of war and destruction, a small sign of intelligence deserves welcome and protection.

Speaker and Tone

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Speaker	A writer at his desk; a person who is both amused and moved. He starts casually and ends sincerely.
Mood	Playful at first, then thoughtful and gentle.
Structure	From a tiny event to a broad claim about mind in nature.
Form	Rhymed couplets in an easy, talking rhythm, lightly humorous.

Themes and Messages

- **Respect for all forms of mind and life.** Even the tiniest being deserves consideration.
- **Intelligence is not only human.** The mite shows caution, planning and fear.
- **Mercy over power.** The poet could crush it but chooses not to.
- **Hope in dark times.** In a year of war, finding intelligence anywhere is a comfort.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Wit and understatement	The tone is relaxed, and the poet describes big matters with a smile.
Irony	The poet intends to kill the speck, yet the speck teaches him respect.
Personification	The mite is said to think, hesitate and fear, as a human would.
Pun on ‘considerable’	Small in size, but worth great consideration.
Conversational diction	Everyday words and a direct address make a serious idea accessible.
Tone	Humorous, then reflective and warm.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
a speck on a white sheet	An ordinary beginning: a tiny interruption.
“it ran with terror and with cunning”	Fear and craft in a creature that cannot even be seen.
“I have a mind myself”	The poet’s ground for respect: mind recognises mind.
“the least display of mind”	Even the smallest sign of thought is a joy.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
considerable	fairly large; also, worthy of attention
illegible	hard to read
cunning	skill in getting what one wants, often by clever tricks
hesitate	pause before acting
mite	a very tiny creature
recognise	to know again, or to acknowledge
guise	outward form or appearance
conscious	aware of one's surroundings

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

The poet is about to stop the speck with a mark of ink when something about its motion makes him think again.

Q. What was the poet doing, and what did he notice?
Ans. He was writing, and he noticed a tiny speck moving over the paper.

Q. What did the poet first intend to do?
Ans. He meant to crush the speck with his pen.

Q. What changed his mind?
Ans. He saw that the speck paused, turned and avoided danger like a thinking creature.

Context

The mite stopped before the wet ink and moved back, as if afraid, and then looked for another route.

Q. Why does the mite avoid the ink?
Ans. It senses the danger of the wet ink and fears being caught.

Q. What does this show about the mite?
Ans. That it has awareness and can plan, which are signs of mind.

Q. What literary device is used in describing the mite?
Ans. Personification, since it is given human feelings of fear and cunning.

Context

Explaining his mercy, the poet says he has a mind himself and recognises ‘mind’ in any form.

Q. Who is speaking and why does he say this?
Ans. The poet is speaking, to explain why he will not kill the mite.

Q. What does ‘in any guise’ mean?
Ans. In any form, however small or strange.

Q. What is the message of these lines?
Ans. That respect for mind and life should extend to all creatures that show them.

Short Answer Questions

Q. What did the poet see on his paper?
Ans. A tiny speck that moved across the sheet as he wrote.

Q. Why did the poet decide not to kill it?
Ans. Its cautious movements showed it had a mind, and the poet felt respect and joy at finding mind in so small a creature.

Q. How does the speck show intelligence?
Ans. It stops at the ink, retreats and looks for another path, which show fear, judgement and planning.

Q. Why is the title appropriate?
Ans. The speck is tiny, but it is ‘considerable’, being worth thought and respect.

Q. What is the poem’s message?
Ans. Intelligence, in whatever form, deserves respect, and the strong should show mercy to the weak.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe how the poet’s attitude to the speck changes in the poem. (about 150 words)
Ans. At first the poet treats the speck as a nuisance and plans to wipe it out with ink. As he watches, he sees that it hesitates, turns away from the wet ink and searches for a safer path. He realises that it has fear and cunning, and so a mind of its own. His attitude shifts from annoyance and power to surprise, interest and respect. He decides to spare it, because he recognises mind wherever he meets it. His feeling of gladness at finding the least display of mind marks the final stage of the change. The poem thus moves from carelessness to mercy.

Q. What larger message lies behind this small incident? (about 150 words)
Ans. Frost uses the incident to suggest that intelligence and life are valuable wherever they are found. The poem was written during a world war, when human beings were destroying one another, and the poet’s delight in a tiny mind is a quiet contrast. The strong poet chooses not to use his power over a helpless creature, and the choice carries a moral lesson. The poem also invites us to look closely at what we ignore and to treat all living things with respect. By combining humour and thoughtfulness, Frost makes a gentle plea for mercy and humility.

HOT Questions

- Is it reasonable to say an insect has a ‘mind’? How does the poem blur the line between instinct and thought?

- Why might Frost have mentioned the war in a poem about a speck?
- If the speck were human-sized, would our response be different? What does that tell us about our attitudes?
- Write the incident from the mite's point of view in five lines.

Quick Recap

- Poet: Robert Frost, American, 1942.
- Story: a speck moves on a page, the poet wants to kill it, sees it has a mind, spares it.
- Themes: respect for mind and life, mercy, hope in wartime.
- Devices: personification, irony, pun on 'considerable', conversational tone.

10

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

The Power of Music

A man who is sure he can sing sends cattle charging, trees running and the sky weeping. Only a goat can stop him. Comic nonsense with a sharp point.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Sukumar Ray
- Nonsense verse
- Hyperbole
- Satire on vanity
- Exam questions

About the Author and the Context

Sukumar Ray (1887 to 1923) was a Bengali writer, illustrator and humorist, famous for nonsense verse. He wrote *Abol Tabol* (often translated as 'Gibberish' or 'Nonsense Rhymes'), a classic of Bengali children's literature. He was the father of the film-maker Satyajit Ray.

The poem is an English version of one of his comic Bengali poems. The speaker is a cheerful narrator who reports, with a straight face, the disaster that follows when **Bhisma Lochan Sharma** decides to sing.



FUN FACT

The title is ironic. Music is supposed to be soothing, but here it is a weapon. The title promises one kind of power and the poem delivers another.

Summary

1. 1. The singer
Bhisma Lochan Sharma, certain of his own talent, begins to sing, and his voice can be heard all the way from Delhi to Burma.

2. 2. Panic among people
As soon as they hear him, people turn pale and run, bringing down everything in their way.

3. 3. Animals revolt
Bullock carts overturn, horses bolt with riders clinging on, cows rear up in protest, and even the fish dive deep into the riverbed to escape the noise.

4. 4. Nature falls apart
Trees pull themselves out of the ground and stumble away, birds fall from the sky, and the heavens themselves begin to weep rain.

5. 5. The goat
A goat, annoyed beyond bearing, lets out a mighty bleat and charges at the singer.

6. 6. Silence
Bhisma is thrown into the air, his concert ends, and the world draws a deep breath in the sudden quiet.

Characters and Speaker

WHO	ROLE
Bhisma Lochan Sharma	The singer: confident, deluded and quite unaware of how awful he sounds. He is the target of the satire.
The goat	The unlikely hero: blunt and brave. It stops the nuisance in the only language he understands.
Humans, animals and trees	The victims, who react more and more wildly as the noise grows.
The narrator	Deadpan and amused; he reports the madness in a serious, matter-of-fact tone.

Themes and Messages

- **Satire on vanity.** Those who think they have talent but lack it can become a public nuisance.
- **Art and noise.** Music without skill or feeling is noise, and no one is obliged to enjoy it.
- **Common sense wins.** The simple goat solves what no civilised person could.
- **The value of silence.** After the chaos, quiet feels like a precious gift.

Tone, Style and Literary Devices

FEATURE	WHERE YOU SEE IT AND WHY IT MATTERS
Hyperbole	The voice is heard from Delhi to Burma, trees uproot themselves, and the sky weeps. Exaggeration is the main engine of the humour.
Irony	The title 'The Power of Music' is the opposite of what happens; the music has the power to cause panic.
Personification	Trees walk, the sky cries and fish seek refuge.
Onomatopoeia	Sounds like thuds, bleats and crashes make the noise 'audible' on the page.
Satire and humour	The poem makes fun of self-deluded performers.
Nonsense logic	Absurd events are described as if they were natural.
Tone	Comic, playful and mock-serious.

Key Lines to Remember

WORDS FROM THE TEXT	WHAT THEY SHOW
voice from Delhi to Burma	Hyperbole: the sound has absurd reach.
faces turning pale	Humans react as to a terror, not a concert.
trees on the run	Nature itself flees from the noise.
the bleating goat	A reply in kind; common sense in action.
the sudden silence	The sweetest part of the music is its ending.

Word Bank

WORD	MEANING IN THIS TEXT
Bhisma	name of the singer, from the Sanskrit for terrifying
bullock cart	a cart drawn by oxen
stampede	a sudden rush of frightened animals or people
bleat	the cry of a goat or sheep
uproot	to pull out by the roots
hyperbole	deliberate exaggeration
deluded	holding a false belief about oneself
cacophony	a harsh mixture of sounds

Reference to Context Questions



SIDEKICK TIP

Locate the lines in the text, say who is speaking and to whom, then answer in your own words. Do not copy the passage back.

Context

Bhisma Lochan Sharma opened his mouth to sing, and his voice carried from Delhi to Burma.

Q. Who is Bhisma Lochan Sharma?
Ans. He is a singer who is convinced of his own talent.

Q. What device is used in saying the voice reached from Delhi to Burma?
Ans. Hyperbole, or deliberate exaggeration.

Q. What does the line suggest about his singing?
Ans. That it is extremely loud and unbearable, so powerful that it covers a whole country.

Context

Trees pulled out their roots and tottered away, birds fell from the sky, and the heavens wept.

Q. What is the effect of this description?
Ans. It humorously shows nature itself being driven mad by the sound.

Q. Which devices are used?
Ans. Personification (trees moving, heavens weeping) and hyperbole.

Q. What is the poet criticising?
Ans. Pompous people who inflict their poor performances on others without realising it.

Context

The goat gave a terrible bleat and charged, and the singer sailed through the air; silence settled over the world.

Q. Why does the goat charge?
Ans. It cannot bear the singing any longer, like all the other creatures.

Q. What is funny about the goat's role?
Ans. A humble animal solves a crisis that nobody else could.

Q. What is the final mood of the poem?
Ans. Relief and quiet, with the joke that silence is the finest music.

Short Answer Questions

Q. Who wrote 'The Power of Music', and what is the poet known for?
Ans. Sukumar Ray, a Bengali humorist and illustrator, known for nonsense verse such as Abol Tabol.

Q. How did people and animals react to Bhisma's singing?
Ans. People turned pale and ran, carts overturned, horses and cows stampeded, and fish dived to the bottom of the river.

Q. How did nature react?
Ans. Trees uprooted themselves, birds dropped, and the sky wept.

Q. Who stopped the singer?
Ans. A goat, which charged at him.

Q. Why is the title ironic?
Ans. Because music should please, but Bhisma's singing frightens everyone and produces chaos.

Long Answer Questions

Q. Show how Sukumar Ray uses hyperbole to create humour in the poem. (about 150 words)
Ans. Ray builds the poem on exaggeration. The singer's voice is heard from Delhi to Burma. People do not simply dislike the sound; they turn pale and stampede. Bullock carts overturn, horses bolt, cattle raise their hooves, and fish plunge to the depths. Then nature joins in: trees pull up their roots, birds fall from the sky and the heavens weep. Each image is more absurd than the last, yet the narrator reports it calmly. The humour comes from this gap between the serious tone and the ridiculous events. Exaggeration also helps the satire, since it shows how unbearable bad singing can be when the singer has no idea.

Q. Discuss the poem as a satire on vanity. (about 150 words)
Ans. Bhisma Lochan Sharma is sure that he sings beautifully, and he insists on sharing his gift. The world's reaction shows how wrong he is. Ray does not scold him; he lets the exaggerated chaos show that self-importance without skill is a nuisance. The goat's attack is a comic judgement on him: the person who ignores everyone's feelings is finally taught a lesson. The poem applies to anyone who forces a poor performance, loud opinions or boring talk on others. Through laughter Ray invites us to be honest about our talents and to consider how our actions affect others.

HOT Questions

- Why might the poet have chosen a goat, not a person, to end the singing?
- Is it fair to laugh at a person who is simply bad at something? Where does satire stop and cruelty begin?
- What would this poem look like if the singer were aware of his own faults?
- Compare the use of exaggeration in this poem with the realistic tone of Haunted Houses.

Quick Recap

- Poet: Sukumar Ray, Bengali humorist, author of Abol Tabol. English version of a comic poem.
- Plot: Bhisma sings, the world panics, nature rebels, a goat charges, silence returns.
- Themes: satire on vanity, art vs noise, value of silence.
- Devices: hyperbole, irony, personification, onomatopoeia. Tone: comic.

11

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LITERATURE

Answer-Writing Toolkit

Knowing the story is half the job. This chapter shows how Paper 2 is set, how to shape each kind of answer, and gives you a one-glance revision sheet for all ten texts.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Paper 2 pattern
- Prose answers
- Poetry answers
- Literary devices
- Revision grid

What the Paper 2 Examiner Wants

SECTION	WHAT THE SYLLABUS SAYS	WHAT YOU DO
Drama (Julius Caesar, Acts III, IV, V)	Questions are central to the text. Excerpts may be given	Covered in the separate Julius Caesar book
Prose (short stories)	Questions are central to the text. Excerpts may be given	Respond clearly, with evidence from the story, in your own words
Poetry	A poem or lines are given. Questions test content, understanding and your personal response to the poem as a whole	Cover the meaning, the feelings and your own reaction



KEY POINT

The Class X paper is set only on the Class X portion: Julius Caesar Acts III to V, the five stories and the five poems prescribed in *Treasure Chest*.

A Three-Step Answer Template

1. Point
Answer the question in one clear sentence.

2. Proof
Support it with a short quotation or a detail from the text.

3. Personal link
Explain what it shows about the character, theme or poet's message, in your own words.



SIDEKICK TIP

Never copy lines from the passage as your answer. The syllabus asks for the answer **in your own words**.

How to Handle Each Question Type

TYPE	LENGTH	METHOD
Reference to context	3 to 5 short answers	Say who is speaking, to whom, where and why. Then explain the lines. Keep each answer to one or two sentences.
Short answer	2 to 4 lines	Answer exactly what is asked. One fact, one reason.
Long answer / character sketch	120 to 150 words	Opening line, three or four points with proof, closing line.
Poem: central idea	3 to 4 lines	State the idea, name the speaker's feeling and one image that supports it.
HOT / opinion	100 to 150 words	Give your view, justify it with two pieces of evidence, and consider the other side briefly.

Reference to Context: A Checklist

1. Identify
Name the text and the speaker. Is it a character, the narrator or the poet?

2. Place
Say where in the story or poem the lines come, and what has just happened.

3. Explain
Put the meaning in your own words. Explain any figure of speech.

4. Connect
Link the lines to character, theme or the poet's message.



BOARD ALERT

Avoid writing 'the poet is saying that...' for every answer. Vary it: 'He means...', 'This shows...', 'The lines suggest...'.

Writing About Poetry

- Start with the **situation**: who is speaking and what is happening.
- Move to the **feeling or message**: what does the poet want us to think or feel?
- Support with **one image or device** and say what it adds.
- Finish with a **personal response**: what struck you, and why?

Literary Devices at a Glance

DEVICE	WHAT IT IS	EXAMPLE FROM THE SYLLABUS
Simile	A comparison using like or as	The moon's bridge of light in *Haunted Houses* is compared to the link with the spirit-world
Metaphor	A direct comparison without like or as	Great trees as great souls in *When Great Trees Fall*
Personification	Giving human qualities to non-human things	The weeping sky and walking trees in *The Power of Music*
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration	A voice heard from Delhi to Burma
Irony	A gap between what is said or expected and what happens	The lit but empty house in *The Pedestrian*
Satire	Using humour to expose faults	The photographer's vanity in *With the Photographer*
Foreshadowing	A hint of what is to come	The crowd at the notice board in *The Last Lesson*
Contrast	Setting opposites side by side	Calm Count and savage lions in *The Glove and the Lions*
Imagery	Language that creates a picture or sensation	The silent glowing houses in *The Pedestrian*
Symbol	Something that stands for an idea	The lift for Martin's trapped fear
Pun	A play on a word with two meanings	'Considerable' in *A Considerable Speck*
Open ending	The story stops without resolving	*The Elevator*

Revision Grid: Stories

STORY	WRITER	SETTING	CENTRAL IDEA	TONE
With the Photographer	Stephen Leacock	A photographer's studio	Be true to yourself; do not be remade by others' taste	Comic, satirical
The Elevator	William Sleator	An old apartment building	Fear of the unknown; a parent who will not listen	Tense, horror
The Girl Who Can	Ama Ata Aidoo	Village of Hasodzi, Ghana	Talent can overturn prejudice about girls and bodies	Warm, triumphant
The Pedestrian	Ray Bradbury	A city in 2053	Technology can crush freedom and curiosity	Eerie, sad
The Last Lesson	Alphonse Daudet	A village school in Alsace	Love of one's language and country	Playful, then solemn

Revision Grid: Poems

POEM	POET	CENTRAL IDEA	KEY DEVICE	TONE
Haunted Houses	H. W. Longfellow	The dead and the spirit-world remain close to us	Personification, imagery	Calm, reflective
The Glove and the Lions	Leigh Hunt	True love needs respect, not a vain test	Narrative, irony	Dramatic, moral
When Great Trees Fall	Maya Angelou	The loss of great souls shakes us, then inspires us	Extended metaphor	Solemn, hopeful
A Considerable Speck	Robert Frost	Mind deserves respect in any form	Personification, pun	Humorous, thoughtful
The Power of Music	Sukumar Ray	Vanity without talent is a nuisance	Hyperbole, irony	Comic

Common Theme Links (for HOT Questions)

THEME	TEXTS THAT SHARE IT
Individual vs authority	The Pedestrian, The Last Lesson, With the Photographer
Fear and isolation	The Elevator, The Pedestrian
Prejudice and self-worth	The Girl Who Can, With the Photographer
Vanity	With the Photographer, The Glove and the Lions, The Power of Music
Respect for life and mind	A Considerable Speck, When Great Trees Fall
Memory and the unseen	Haunted Houses, When Great Trees Fall
Language and identity	The Last Lesson



SIDEKICK TIP

In a HOT answer, linking two texts through a shared theme earns credit, as long as the main focus stays on the text asked about.

Last-Minute Checklist

- Know each writer's name and nationality, and the year of writing where it is a famous fact.
- Know the beginning, turning point and ending of each story.
- Be able to give the central idea of every poem in one sentence.
- Learn two or three key phrases per text, but quote only a few words at a time.

- Write every answer in your own words and in complete sentences.

Done reading?
Now go break the board.



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Sidekick · English Literature · ICSE Class 10 · 2027 syllabus edition
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